

Ethics in Action: Thinking Critically About Real-World Dilemmas

How should we decide what to do when more than one answer seems right?

Every day we face situations where the right choice is not obvious. This course explores how we can think carefully about those decisions using tools from ethics, logic, and critical reasoning.

Instructor: Rubén Arturo Rodríguez Barrón

Meeting Times: Tu/Th 10:00 to 11:30 at Cobb Hall 101

Recommended Prerequisites: Introduction to Critical Thinking

Course Description

This course explores how people make difficult decisions. The focus is on applying critical thinking to real situations, not on abstract theories.

Students will discuss famous cases and news stories, examine different sides of contemporary issues, and practice explaining and defending their ideas. Cases will be drawn from a variety of sources, with a focus on real-world issues in business, technology, government, and society.

Learning Goals

The goal of the course is to help students think about how their decisions affect themselves and others. Students will learn skills that are useful in school, in the workplace, and in everyday life.

By the end of the course, students will be able to:

- Understand what makes a situation an ethical dilemma
- Identify the key issues and trade-offs in real-world cases
- Explain different sides of an argument clearly and fairly
- Recognize common reasoning mistakes and biases when they appear
- Use evidence and reasoning to support their own views
- Discuss difficult topics respectfully, even when people disagree
- Make thoughtful decisions and explain the reasoning behind them

How the Class Works

Each session is 90 minutes long and built around a case, but the format changes with the case. Depending on the session, students take on roles, stage a simulation, work in teams, map arguments, debate both sides, or bring and present their own cases. The instructor introduces each case and its background; the rest of the session belongs to the students.

There are no single “right” answers in many of the cases we will discuss. The goal is to practice explaining your reasoning clearly and engaging respectfully with different viewpoints.

Because the course is designed to stay relevant, some cases and topics may change during the term to reflect important current events. This allows the class to engage with issues that are actively shaping the world.

More details about the cases for each session are provided in the course schedule below.

Evaluation and Attendance Policy

Grades in this course are based primarily on participation in class discussions.

- Participation and Discussion: 70%
- Attendance: 20%
- Final Reflection: 10%

Participation is not about speaking the most, but about contributing thoughtfully. Students are expected to engage with the material, respond to others, and explain their reasoning clearly.

The Collegiate Scholars Program has a strict attendance policy. If you miss more than 2 classes or are late more than 3 times, you will not receive course credit.

Classroom Discussion and Respectful Dialogue

This course examines difficult ethical questions and real-world dilemmas. As a result, students will encounter ideas and perspectives that may challenge their assumptions or differ from their own views.

Thoughtful disagreement and open debate are an essential part of the learning process. Students are expected to engage with difficult questions seriously, listen carefully to others, and respond with reasoned arguments.

A willingness to consider challenging ideas and participate in respectful but candid discussion is an important part of the course.

Course Schedule

Part I: Foundations

Session 1 (June 23) – Introduction to Ethics

Is it ever right to do something that looks wrong?

Think-pair-share. Students reason through a short scenario with a partner, then as a class, working out whether an action is right or wrong because of the act itself, the intention behind it, or its outcome.

Session 2 (June 25) – Foundations of Ethical Thinking

If everyone thinks something is right, does that make it right?

Worked example. We separate moral disagreement from the claim that there is no right answer. Then the instructor models the routine used all term (facts, stakeholders, options, reasons) on a short case before students run it themselves.

Part II: Business

Session 3 (June 30) – Case: The Ford Pinto

Is following the letter of the law enough?

Role-play. Students take the roles of engineers, executives, regulators, and victims' families, and argue whether meeting federal safety standards settled Ford's decision about the Pinto's fuel tank.

Session 4 (July 2) – In the News: Business

What should these companies have done?

Team case analysis. The instructor brings a set of short, recent cases from different companies and industries and assigns one to each team. Each team works through its case with the routine, reaches a decision, and explains it to the whole class.

Part III: Technology

Session 5 (July 7) – Case: The Boeing 737 MAX

When a system fails, who is responsible: the engineer, the company, or the regulator?

Decision mapping. Students build a timeline of the choices behind the aircraft's flight-control software and its certification, marking each point where someone could have stopped the failure.

Session 6 (July 9) – Technology Mini Cases

Is the argument good, or does it just sound good?

Argument mapping and steelmanning. After a short primer on formal and informal fallacies, teams diagram arguments about AI, facial recognition, student privacy, and school safety. They name the fallacies, then rebuild the strongest version of each side.

Part IV: Government

Session 7 (July 14) – *An Enemy of the People*, Acts I–III

What do you owe the truth when it costs your community?

Close reading. Students work through key scenes in which Dr. Stockmann discovers the town's baths are contaminated. They debate whether the town's leaders are protecting or betraying the public, and connect him to the engineers from the Pinto and Boeing cases.

Session 8 (July 16) – *An Enemy of the People*, Acts IV–V

Can the majority be wrong, and who gets to decide?

Simulation. Students stage the town meeting, arguing for and against Stockmann's claim that the majority is never right, then apply the question to public health and democratic government.

Part V: Society

Session 9 (July 21) – Case: Harvard Admissions and Affirmative Action

Can treating everyone the same ever be unfair?

Switch-sides debate. Students argue one side of *SFFA v. Harvard* (2023), then switch and argue the other, testing whether their view changes when fairness is owed to individuals rather than to groups.

Session 10 (July 23) – In the News: Society

Which of these stories is really an ethical problem, and why?

Student-sourced news roundtable. Each student brings a recent article on a controversy of their own choosing (e.g., influencers caught passing off AI-generated images as real, classmates cheating on a test) and briefly presents it. The class then chooses the cases it finds most compelling and works through them together.

Part VI: Your Cases

Session 11 (July 28) – Student Cases I

Student-authored cases. The first half of the class presents their one-page cases. Classmates run the routine, and each presenter leaves with at least one option they hadn't considered.

Session 12 (July 30) – Student Cases II and Closing

Presentations and synthesis. The remaining cases, then a closing discussion on which reasons held up across every case this term. Final Reflection due.

Student Cases

At the end of the course, students will create a short, one-page case based on a real or realistic situation that involves an ethical dilemma. The case may be based on a personal experience, something observed at school/online, or a real-world issue discussed during the course.

Students should clearly describe the situation and present a decision that must be made.

Each case should include:

- A brief description of the situation
- The key decision or dilemma
- At least two reasonable options
- A short explanation of why the situation is ethically challenging

Students will share their cases in class, and we will use them as the basis for discussion.

The goal of this assignment is not to find a single “correct” answer, but to create a situation that encourages thoughtful discussion and careful reasoning.